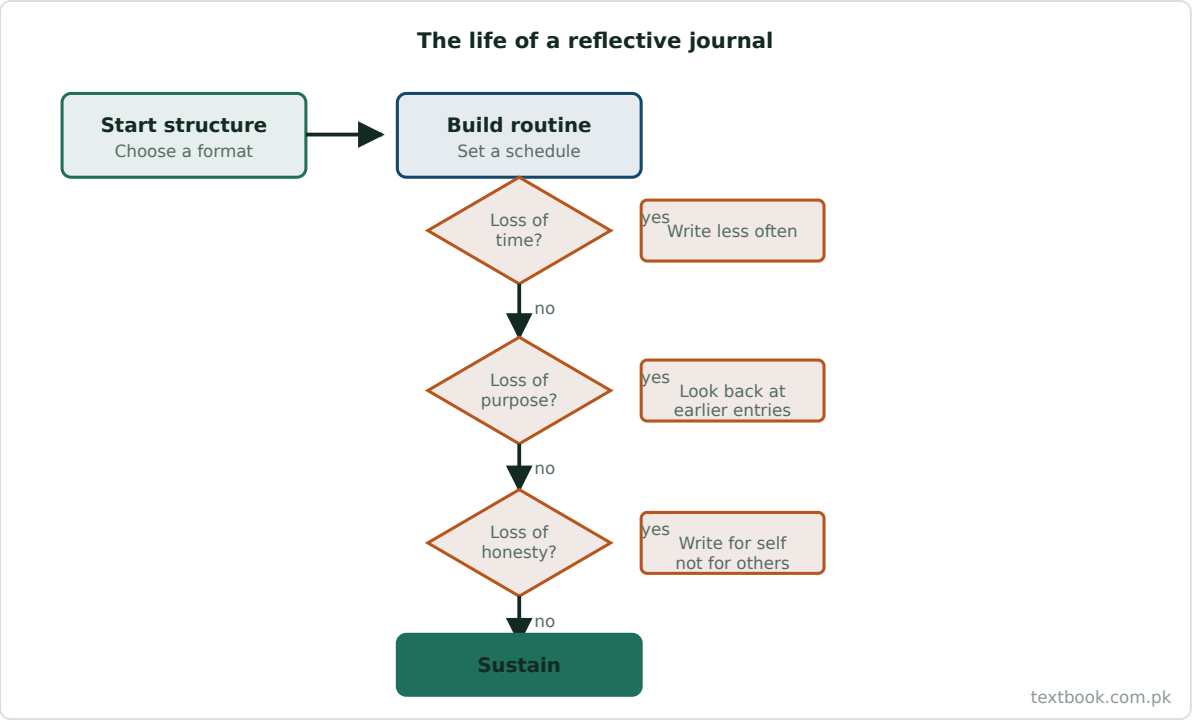
Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform’s automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Topic 6.2 - Creating one, and keeping it alive

A real classroom situation

Miss Farah starts her reflection file in week 1 with enthusiasm. She writes three entries in the first week, two in the second, one in the third. In week 4 she misses a week. In week 6 she has not written anything for two weeks and the notebook sits at the bottom of her bag. By week 10 she is writing five entries in two days before the submission deadline. The supervisor's comment: "The early entries show promise. The later ones are rushed and thin. The final three read like they were written the night before."



textbook.com.pk

Miss Farah's story is the most common one in assessed reflection files. The writing is not the problem. The structure and the routine are. This topic gives you both.

Explanation

The structural elements

A reflective journal for assessment needs four structural elements. Without them, the journal either dies (Miss Farah) or drifts into diary-writing (Topic 6.1).

1. A consistent format. Use one model for every entry. Gibbs (Topic 5.4) is the natural choice for an assessed file because its six stages give the marker a clear structure to assess. Every entry should have the same headings: description, feelings, evaluation, analysis, conclusion, action plan. The format does not have to be Gibbs - any named model works - but

it has to be the *same* format throughout, because the marker is looking for evidence of a process, not a collection of one-off thoughts.

2. A regular schedule. Write at least once a week, on the same day if possible. The schedule is what keeps the journal alive: "every Friday after the last period" is sustainable; "when I have time" is not, because there is never time. Jasper (2003) notes that the single strongest predictor of a journal that survives a term is not motivation but routine. Motivation fades. Routine does not.

3. A link between entries. Every entry after the first should open with a sentence referring to the previous one: "Last week I tried X. This week I found Y." That sentence is the return arrow from Unit 5, and it is what turns a collection of entries into a sustained inquiry. Without it, each entry is a fresh start, and the marker cannot see learning accumulating.

4. A dated, titled record. Every entry should have a date and a brief title that names the incident or issue. The date lets the marker see the spacing (weekly, not bunched before the deadline). The title lets the writer find an entry later. A journal without dates and titles is a notebook, not a file.

Surviving vs dying journal

Surviving journal	Dying journal
Format Consistent structure same sections each entry	Varying or no structure different each time
Schedule Fixed day and time protected in the week	When there is time easily postponed
Links Present across entries references to earlier writing	Absent each entry stands alone
Record Dated and titled clear reference points	Undated or untitled hard to find later

textbook.com.pk

textbook.com.pk

Why journals die - and the remedies

Most reflective journals die for one of three reasons. Each has a remedy.

Failure 1 - Loss of time. The teacher gets busy (examination season, school events, personal crisis) and the journal stops. *Remedy:* write less, but write. An entry that is five sentences long on a busy week is better than no entry at all. The marker rewards consistency over length. A short entry every week beats a long entry every month.

Failure 2 - Loss of purpose. The teacher stops seeing the point. "I am writing every Friday and nothing is changing." *Remedy:* look back. Read the entries from the first month. The changes are real but gradual, and they are invisible week to week. They become visible across a month. This is what Jasper (2003) calls "the revisible record" - the journal's power is in the looking back, not in the writing.

Failure 3 - Loss of honesty. The teacher starts writing what they think the supervisor wants to rather than what they actually experienced. Entries become safe, bland and generic. *Remedy:* write for yourself first. A journal

that records a genuine failure and a genuine uncertainty is worth more than a journal that records a tidy success every week. Supervisors can tell the difference, and they mark the honest one higher, because honesty is a prerequisite for learning. If you write a safe entry every week, you are keeping a diary of performances, not a journal of practice.

The assessed file: what your marker looks for

The guide's reflection file is 10 marks. While the exact assessment criteria vary by institution, the standard academic expectations are consistent:

- **Regularity** - at least one entry per week across the term, dated and spaced.
- **Structure** - each entry follows a named reflective model consistently.
- **Analysis** - entries move beyond description to evidence-based analysis. A journal that is all description and no analysis is a diary, and a diary gets low marks.
- **Development** - later entries show more depth than earlier ones. The marker is looking for growth across the file, not just within individual entries.
- **Honesty** - the file records genuine incidents, including failures, and examines them honestly.

> **Common misconception: "longer entries are better entries."** They are not. A 300-word entry that reaches analysis is worth more than a 600-word entry that stays descriptive. The mark scheme rewards depth, not length. Taggart and Wilson (2005) note that concise, focused reflection is more useful than lengthy unfocused writing, and markers agree.

> ## Activity: Plan your journal

Work individually, then share with a partner. About 20 minutes.

Plan your assessed reflection file for this course. Write down:

1. Which model you will use for every entry (and why that one).
2. Which day of the week you will write, and for how many minutes.
3. How you will link each entry to the previous one (what the opening sentence will do).
4. How you will format the entry (headings, date, title).

Then share with a partner. For each plan, say whether it is sustainable for a full term. Where it is not, say which of the three failure modes (time, purpose, honesty) is most likely to bite, and what the remedy would be.

Check your understanding

1. **Remember** Name the four structural elements a reflective journal for assessment needs.

2. **Understand** In two or three sentences, explain why a fixed writing schedule matters more than motivation.

3. **Apply** A trainee writes, "I will write when something interesting happens." Using this topic, explain why that plan will fail and what the fix is.

4. **Apply** A journal has twelve entries, all dated, all using Gibbs, but each entry is completely unrelated to the one before. What is missing, and why does it matter for the mark?

Summary

A reflective journal needs four structural elements: a consistent format, a regular schedule, a link between entries and a dated, titled record. Journals die from loss of time, loss of purpose or loss of honesty, and each has a remedy (write less but write; look back across weeks; write honestly for yourself first). The assessed file rewards regularity, structure, analysis, development and honesty

- not length. A short, honest, linked entry every week is worth more than a long, safe, isolated entry every month.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can name the four structural elements a reflective journal needs.
- [ ] I can name the three reasons journals die and the remedy for each.
- [ ] I can plan a journal that is sustainable for a full term.
- [ ] I can say what the marker of an assessed reflection file looks for.

Try this at your practicum school

This week, set a specific day and time for your journal writing. Write your first entry using Gibbs' six stages. Before you write the second entry next week, read the first one and write an opening sentence that links to it. Bring both entries to your tutorial.

Summative task

Here is a trainee's journal plan:

> "I will write my reflection file every day after school. Each entry will be at least one page. I will write about the best thing that happened each day. I will make sure every entry is positive and shows my growth as a teacher."

Write 200 to 250 words that (a) identifies three problems with this plan, using the failure modes and the structural elements from this topic, and (b) rewrites the plan so it is sustainable for a full term and would meet the marker's expectations.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	Levels
Problem identification	0-3: three problems identified with reasons tied to the topic (daily is unsustainable, one page rewards length over depth, only-positive kills honesty) / two identified / one or none.
Plan rewrite	0-3: a rewritten plan that addresses all three problems and names a model, a schedule, a linking strategy and a record format (**Analyze*: the rewrite turns on the specific failure modes, not on general advice) / a rewrite that addresses some problems / no real rewrite.
Marker expectations	0-2: names at least three of the five marker expectations (regularity, structure, analysis, development, honesty) / names one or two / none.

Criterion	Levels
Clarity	0-2: within the word band and organised under the two parts / unclear or over length.

Further reading

Jasper, M. (2003). *Beginning reflective practice*. Nelson Thornes. Chapter 3 covers structure and routine.

Taggart, G. L., & Wilson, A. P. (2005). *Promoting reflective thinking in teachers: 50 action strategies* (2nd ed.). Corwin Press. The introduction discusses what assessors look for in reflective writing.

Was this page helpful? Yes

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback